

Postmortem: Orders database outage, 14 March 2026 (SEV1)

Summary

On 14 March 2026 the orders API was unavailable for 47 minutes, from 10:12 to 10:59 IST. Approximately 18,000 checkout requests failed. No data was lost.

Root cause

A schema migration added an index to the orders table without using CONCURRENTLY. The migration took an exclusive lock on the table, which blocked all writes. Connection pools on the orders API filled up with waiting connections and health checks began failing, which caused the load balancer to remove every instance. The migration had been approved but had not been tested against a production-sized dataset.

Timeline

10:12 migration started by the deploy pipeline. 10:15 alerts fired for checkout error rate. 10:19 SEV1 declared and Incident Commander assigned. 10:41 the migration was identified as the cause and cancelled. 10:59 error rates returned to normal.

Action items

1. Add a CI lint rule that rejects CREATE INDEX without CONCURRENTLY on large tables (owner: Data Platform, due 31 March 2026). 2. Run all migrations against a staging copy with production-sized data before approval (owner: Release Engineering, due 15 April 2026). 3. Set lock_timeout to 5 seconds for migration sessions (owner: Data Platform, due 21 March 2026). 4. Add a dashboard panel for database lock waits (owner: SRE, due 31 March 2026).

What went well

Alerting fired within 3 minutes and the status page was updated within 10 minutes of declaration.